1.10.5 Variation of acceleration due to gravity (g):

Since, g depends on the geometric radius of the Earth, ($g \propto 1/R^2$), its value changes from one place to another on the surface of the Earth. Since, the geometric radius of the Earth is maximum in the equatorial region and minimum in the polar region, the value of g is maximum in the polar region and minimum at the equatorial region.

When you move to a higher altitude from the surface of the Earth, the value of g reduces. In the same way, when you move deep below the surface of the Earth, the value of g reduces. (This topic will be discussed in detail in the higher classes). Value of g is zero at the centre of the Earth.

1.11 MASS AND WEIGHT

Mass: Mass is the basic property of a body. Mass of a body is defined as the quantity of matter contained in the body. Its SI unit is kilogram (kg).

Weight: Weight of a body is defined as the gravitational force exerted on a body due to the gravity.

Weight = Gravitational Force

= mass (m)× acceleration due to gravity(g).

g = acceleration due to gravity for Earth (at sea level) = 9.8 ms^{-2}.

Weight is a vector quantity. Direction of weight is always towards the centre of the Earth. SI unit of weight is newton (N). Weight of a body varies from one place to another place on the Earth since it depends on the acceleration due to gravity of the Earth (g) weight of a body is more at the poles than at the equatorial region.

The value of acceleration due to gravity on the surface of the moon is 1.625 ms^{-2}. This is about 0.1654 times the acceleration due to gravity of the Earth. If a person whose mass is 60 kg stands on the surface of Earth, his weight would be 588 N (W = mg = 60 × 9.8). If the same person goes to the surface of the Moon, he would weigh only 97.5 N (W = 60 × 1.625). But, his mass remains the same (60 kg) on both the Earth and the Moon.

1.12 APPARENT WEIGHT

The weight that you feel to possess during up and down motion, is not same as your actual weight. Apparent weight is the weight of the body acquired due to the action of gravity and other external forces acting on the body.

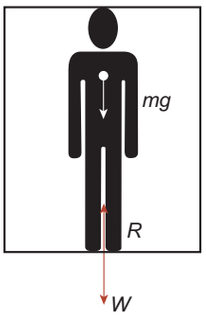


Figure 1.10
A person in a moving lift

Let us see this from the following illustration:

Let us consider a person of mass m, who is travelling in lift. The actual weight of the person is W = mg, which is acting vertically downwards. **The reaction force exerted by the lift's surface 'R', taken as apparent weight** is acting vertically upwards.

Let us see different possibilities of the apparent weight 'R' of the person that arise, depending on the motion of the lift; upwards or downwards which are given in Table 1.2

1.12.1 Weightlessness

Have you gone to an amusement park and taken a ride in a roller coaster? or in a giant wheel? During the fast downward and upward movement, how did you feel?

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